Secrets in Source 2

Date: 5/3/2026
Platform: HackerDNA
URL: https://hackerdna.com/labs/secrets-in-source-2

Objective

Bypass client-side protections designed to block inspection and uncover sensitive information hidden within the webpage source.

Step 1: Initial Access

Navigated to the provided lab URL:

https://lab.hdna.me/145-secrets-in-source-2

The page loaded a homepage for **SecureVault Technologies**, a cybersecurity company.

Step 2: Identify Client-Side Restrictions

Attempted standard inspection methods:

F12 → blocked
Right-click → disabled
Ctrl + U → blocked

Observation:

The application attempts to prevent users from:

- Opening Developer Tools
- Viewing page source
- Inspecting elements

These protections are implemented using **client-side JavaScript**. They only affect the browser interface; not the underlying data.

Step 3: Bypass Client-Side Protections

Used a browser-level override (directly in URL bar):

view-source:https://lab.hdna.me/145-secrets-in-source-2/

This bypasses JavaScript restrictions and displays the raw HTML.

```
      .grid {
        grid-template-columns: 1fr;
      }
    }
  </style>
</head>
<body>
  <!-- Secret Flag: /s3cr3t_v4u1t_92x7h/flag.txt -->
  <!-- Don't even try to view the source, it's protected! -->

  <nav class="navbar">
    <div class="nav-container">
```

Step 4: Source Code Analysis

Reviewing the source revealed developer comments:

<!-- Secret Flag: /s3cr3t_v4u1t_92x7h/flag.txt -->
<!-- Don't even try to view the source, it's protected! -->

Issue: Information Disclosure

- Sensitive file path exposed in HTML comments
- No access control protecting the resource
- False assumption that blocking DevTools prevents access

Step 5: Exploitation

Navigated directly to the exposed endpoint:

https://lab.hdna.me/145-secrets-in-source-2/s3cr3t_v4u1t_92x7h/flag.txt

---

Result / Flag

Successfully retrieved the flag from the exposed file.

(Flag omitted intentionally for integrity of the challenge)

Key Takeaways:

1. Client-side protections (blocking DevTools, right-click, etc.) do not provide real security.
2. Users can always access raw HTML through alternative methods (e.g., view-source, curl).
3. Sensitive data should never be embedded in client-accessible code.
4. Security through obscurity (hidden paths) is ineffective.
5. Always assume attackers can see everything sent to the browser.